fence stretching across the twenty-nine-mile division between East and West Berlin and around the ninety-seventy-mile circumference. When the barbed wire was replaced by a concrete barrier, the Berlin Wall came to symbolise the division of Europe. The West was taken by surprise by the *fait accompli*, even though Oleg Penkovsky learned of the impending action four days earlier (but had no means of communicating this to his handlers).[32]

Kennedy's reaction was prescient. 'Why would Khrushchev put up a wall,' he asked Kenny O'Donnell, 'if he really intended to seize West Berlin? There wouldn't be any need of a wall if he occupied the whole of the city. This is his way out of his predicament. It's not a very nice solution, but a wall is a hell of a lot better than a war.'[33]

Harold Macmillan took a similar view, but mistakenly made this public, privately admitting he 'rather lost [his] temper' (when ambushed by journalists on the final hole of Gleneagles golf course) and dismissed the crisis as having been 'got up by the press', declaring, 'Nobody is going to fight about [the wall].'[34]

In Europe and the United States there was criticism of Kennedy's lack of action. It took several days before Washington coordinated a public response. Meanwhile, consolidation of the Wall (or rather at this stage, the Wire) proceeded and US (as well as British and French) troops looked on but took no action. Kennedy decided to send (a reluctant) Vice President Johnson to West Berlin, together with General Lucius D. Clay, remembered there as the architect of the Berlin Airlift of 1948–49. Johnson was met with huge cheering crowds and on 20 August greeted a force of 1,500 US troops who had driven down the autobahn to strengthen the US garrison and signal Washington's commitment to the city.

The Berlin Wall staunched the haemorrhage of skilled workers from the GDR, though at political cost to Moscow's credibility (and the humanitarian cost of over a hundred people killed attempting to flee across the border). The wall did not, however, solve the problems that had brought East and West into confrontation. Berlin remained both the bone stuck in Khrushchev's throat and the testicles of the West that he could squeeze when he chose. Yet the wall appeared to defuse the tension generated, or at